

PUNCHING ABOVE, LOOKING BEYOND

For the Associate nations, this T20 World Cup was a tournament of inches. A catch not taken, a handful of runs conceded, a chase left unfinished. **They proved they belong.** The question that lingers is whether the game's architecture is ready to meet their ambition.

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The Netherlands was perhaps one catch away from pulling off the first major upset of the T20 World Cup 2026. Had Faheem Ashraf departed in the 19th over, Pakistan was all but done.

The chance went down. Ashraf capitalised. Twenty-nine runs came off the final two overs, and victory was snatched from the jaws of defeat.

"I want to be very clear: Pakistan didn't win the game today, we lost the game ourselves," the Netherlands pacer Paul van Meekeren said afterwards.

Closing gaps

That match set the tone for what followed from the Associate nations in the league stage: fightbacks, sustained pressure on full-member sides and long spells of dominance. It is unfortunate that none ultimately crossed the line against the very top

teams.

Later that day, the USA reduced defending champion India to 77 for six before Suryakumar Yadav steadied the innings and took his side to a competitive total, eventually sealing a 29-run win. The next day, Nepal came agonisingly close to beating England, losing by four runs despite needing only 13 off the final nine balls with five wickets in hand.

"More matches against top teams help you handle pressure moments better. Experience comes from repeatedly being in those situations," USA's Shayan Jahangir said.

This World Cup made one thing clear: Associate nations are no longer content to participate; they expect to compete. The closely fought matches, resilience under pressure and individual skill on display showed they belong at this level.

Italy, making its T20 World Cup debut, defeated Nepal and stayed competitive against England until the end.

"We came here wanting to win games, so I wouldn't say we exceeded expectations. We gave it a proper go. That's what we demanded of ourselves," Italy captain Wayne

Madsen reflected.

There has clearly been a shift in mindset. These teams are more competitive and tactically sharper. Yet most of their exposure still comes within the Associate circuit. ICC qualifiers, regional tournaments and domestic leagues remain their primary platforms for growth.

"The Nepal Premier League (NPL) is very important for Nepali players. It is one of the best T20 tournaments in the country," captain Rohit Paudel said. "Many local players who don't often get national team opportunities gain exposure there. They share dressing rooms with experienced international players and learn from them. That experience is invaluable." Players like Shakib Al Hasan, David Warner and Shikhar Dhawan have appeared in the NPL.

Limited exposure

In September 2025, Nepal played its first and only bilateral series against a full member, the West Indies. It won the three-match series 2-1. In the 2024 T20 World Cup, it fell one run short of beating South Africa in the group stage.

"After that World Cup game